

# Clinical Dialogue Transcript — ADHD

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| Therapist Model:      | gpt-4o               |
| Patient Model:        | llama-3.1-8b-instant |
| Condition / DSM-5:    | ADHD                 |
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| Total Dialogue Turns: | 21                   |

## THERAPIST (Turn 1)

Hi, thanks for coming in today. What's been going on for you lately?

## PATIENT (Turn 2)

It's just, you know, the usual stuff. Work's been...fine, I guess. I mean, I have a lot of ideas and stuff, but I just can't seem to follow through on 'em. Like, I'll start a project and then I'll be all excited about it for a day, and then I'll just get distracted by something else. My boss is always on my case about meeting deadlines, but it's just hard for me to stay focused, you know?

## THERAPIST (Turn 3)

It sounds like you're experiencing some difficulty with maintaining focus and follow-through on your projects, especially with the pressure from your boss. This can be really frustrating, especially when you have ideas you're excited about. Sometimes, understanding what's behind the difficulty to focus can be the first step in addressing it.

Do you notice any patterns or specific situations that make it harder for you to stay on track? Or are there times when you find it easier to concentrate? This might help us identify any underlying factors that could be contributing to this challenge.

## PATIENT (Turn 4)

Patterns? Um, well...I guess I'm one of those people who gets really excited and motivated when I start something new, but then I just lose steam after a while. It's like my brain just...checks out, I don't know. And it's not just work, it's everything, really. I'll be in the middle of a conversation and I'll start thinking about something else that just occurred to me, or I'll be in the middle of a task and I'll remember that I need to do something else, and then I'm off doing that instead. It's like my brain doesn't want to cooperate, you know?

### **THERAPIST (Turn 5)**

It sounds like you're describing a pattern of initial excitement followed by a drop in motivation and difficulty maintaining focus across different areas of your life. This can be challenging, especially when it feels like your mind is pulling you in different directions.

Sometimes, this kind of experience can be related to how our brains process and prioritize information. It might be helpful to explore some strategies to manage this, such as breaking tasks into smaller, more manageable steps or using tools like timers or reminders to help keep your focus on track.

Have you tried any strategies in the past to help with this, or is there anything in particular you'd like to explore or try in our sessions to address these challenges?

### **PATIENT (Turn 6)**

Yeah, I've tried all sorts of things, but nothing really sticks, you know? I mean, I'll try to make to-do lists and stuff, but then I'll just lose the lists or forget about them altogether. And I've tried using timers and reminders, but it's hard to stay on track when I'm just not that interested in what I'm doing. I'm just bad at adulting, I guess. Oh, wait, what was the question again?

### **THERAPIST (Turn 7)**

It sounds like you've been trying different strategies but are finding it difficult to stick with them, especially when you're not interested in the tasks. It's understandable to feel this way, and it doesn't mean you're "bad at adulting." It's more about finding what works for you and understanding how your mind operates.

Given what you've shared, it might be helpful to explore ways to increase engagement or interest in tasks or to connect tasks with personal goals or values that are meaningful to you. Sometimes reframing tasks or finding aspects of them that align with your interests can help maintain motivation.

Additionally, it might be beneficial to look at any underlying factors contributing to these challenges, such as stress, anxiety, or even how you structure your day. Would you be open to exploring these areas further, or is there a specific aspect you'd like to focus on first?

### **PATIENT (Turn 8)**

Yeah, I guess that makes sense. I mean, I just feel like I'm not very good at organizing my time or prioritizing things, so it's hard to know where to start. I do get stressed out a lot, especially when I'm trying to meet deadlines or keep up with work stuff. But, I don't know, it just feels like I'm always playing catch-up, you know? Oh, and I just remembered I have to pick up milk on the way home from here, I totally forgot that. Sorry, what were we talking about again?

### **THERAPIST (Turn 9)**

It sounds like you're juggling a lot, and the stress of trying to keep up with everything is adding to the challenge. It's understandable that organizing time and prioritizing tasks can feel overwhelming, especially when you're under pressure.

Let's take a step back and think about how we can approach this in a manageable way. One thing we might explore is developing a routine or system that can help you prioritize tasks and manage your time, perhaps in a way that incorporates flexibility to account for distractions. This might involve setting aside specific times for planning and reviewing your tasks, or even using simple methods to capture those little reminders, like needing to pick up milk, so they don't add to your mental load.

It's also important to address the stress and how it affects your ability to focus. Finding stress-relief techniques that work for you could be beneficial. We can look into mindfulness practices, breathing exercises, or other stress management tools that might help reduce the feeling of playing catch-up.

How does that sound to you? Are there any particular strategies you've heard of or are curious about that we could explore together?

### **PATIENT (Turn 10)**

Yeah, that sounds okay, I guess. I mean, I've tried some of those mindfulness things before, but I never really stuck with it. And I've used planners and stuff, but I just end up losing them or forgetting to use them. I don't know, it's hard to get motivated to do all that when it feels like it's just going to be another thing to worry about. Oh, actually, I just remembered I have a meeting at work tomorrow and I need to make a presentation, and I haven't even started working on it yet...

### **THERAPIST (Turn 11)**

It sounds like there's a lot on your plate right now, and the thought of adding new habits or tools can feel overwhelming, especially when you're already feeling stretched thin. It's completely normal to feel that way.

Let's focus on the immediate concern of your presentation. It might help to break it down into smaller, more manageable parts so it feels less daunting. For example, you could start by jotting down key points or ideas you want to include, and then focus on creating one slide or section at a time. Setting short, timed intervals for working on it might also help maintain focus and momentum without feeling overwhelming.

Once we get through this immediate task, we can take a closer look at how to make mindfulness or organizational strategies work for you in a way that feels sustainable and not like another burden. It's important to find an approach that fits into your life and feels supportive rather than stressful.

Would you like to brainstorm some quick steps for starting your presentation, or is there another way I can support you with this task right now?

### **PATIENT (Turn 12)**

Yeah, breaking it down into smaller parts sounds doable, I guess. I mean, I've done presentations before, but this one is just feeling really hard to get started on. Okay, so I'll start by making a list of key points...but I just remembered I need to pick up that dry cleaning on the way home, too. And I still haven't paid that bill I've been putting off. Ugh, I'm just so overwhelmed...

### **THERAPIST (Turn 13)**

It sounds like everything is piling up, and it's understandable to feel overwhelmed when there are multiple tasks competing for your attention. Let's take a moment to pause and breathe. It's okay to feel this way, and we're here to work through it together.

Starting with your presentation, making a list of key points is a great first step. After that, you can set aside short, focused periods for each section. It could help to tackle it in 15- to 20-minute blocks, with short breaks in between, to keep it from feeling too daunting.

For the other tasks, like picking up dry cleaning or paying the bill, it might help to jot them down in a simple list or on your phone so they're out of your head and you can approach them one at a time. Sometimes, just organizing these tasks outside of your mind can create a bit of mental space.

Remember, it's okay to prioritize. Maybe focus on the most time-sensitive tasks first, like the presentation and bill, and then plan for the dry cleaning.

Would you like to create a quick plan together for how you might approach these tasks today? Or perhaps there's a specific area where you'd like some more focused support right now?

### PATIENT (Turn 14)

I guess making a list and breaking it down into smaller blocks sounds...manageable, I suppose. But, um, I'm not really sure where to start. I mean, I've got all these tasks floating around in my head, and I don't know how to prioritize them. And, oh, wait, I just remembered I had a phone call with my mom earlier today and I totally forgot to respond to her. I'm just so...scatterbrained, I guess.

### THERAPIST (Turn 15)

It sounds like there are a lot of competing demands on your attention right now, and it's understandable to feel scatterbrained when you're trying to juggle so much at once. Let's try to create a bit of order and prioritize these tasks together.

Here's a simple approach we can try:

1. **Brain Dump**: Take a few minutes to write down all the tasks that are on your mind, big or small. This can be on paper, your phone, or any tool you find easy to access. Don't worry about the order—just get everything out of your head.
2. **Prioritize**: Once everything is listed, identify which tasks are most urgent or time-sensitive. You could use categories like "urgent," "important," and "can wait" to help sort them.
3. **Action Plan**: For the most urgent tasks, like your presentation and responding to your mom, decide on small, actionable steps you can take today. For example, spend 15 minutes on the presentation key points, and set a reminder to call or text your mom.
4. **Schedule**: Consider scheduling specific times for each task, even if it's just approximations. This can help you see the day more clearly and create a structure to follow.
5. **Review and Adjust**: At the end of the day, revisit your list and see what you've accomplished and what might need to be carried over to tomorrow. This can also be a moment to acknowledge your efforts and adjust priorities as needed.

How does this approach sound to you? Would you like to try it now, or is there something else you'd like to focus on first?

### PATIENT (Turn 16)

I guess that sounds okay, I mean, it's a plan, right? \*laughs nervously\* Okay, um, let me just get a pen and paper... \*pauses\* Oh, wait, I think I left my pen in my other bag. And I need to get that bag from the other room... \*gets up and starts to walk away\*

### THERAPIST (Turn 17)

Take your time, and no rush. It's great that you're taking the first step in organizing your thoughts. When you're ready, feel free to come back, and we can continue going through the list together.

If you find that getting started is often interrupted by other tasks or thoughts, it might help to have a dedicated spot or tool for capturing these thoughts as they occur, like a notepad or an app on your phone. This way, you can quickly jot down anything that pops up without getting too sidetracked.

Let me know when you're ready, and we can continue with your plan. And remember, it's perfectly okay to take things one step at a time.

### PATIENT (Turn 18)

\*sighs\* Yeah, okay...I'll try to get back to it. \*pauses\* You know, it's just hard for me to focus on one thing for too long. I get bored or distracted easily, and it feels like I'm constantly switching between tasks. I don't know, maybe I'm just not cut out for this whole organization thing...

### THERAPIST (Turn 19)

It's completely understandable to feel that way, especially when staying focused and organized feels like a constant battle. The important thing to remember is that everyone has their unique way of processing information and managing tasks, and it's okay if the traditional methods don't work for you.

We can explore alternative methods that might align better with how you naturally operate. For example, some people find success with a more dynamic approach, like time-blocking with flexibility or using a "two-minute rule" where you tackle any task that takes two minutes or less right away, keeping the momentum going.

It's also about finding ways to make tasks more engaging or connecting them to something meaningful to you, which can help sustain focus even when it feels like a struggle.

You're not alone in this, and it's okay to experiment with different strategies until you find something that feels right. Would you like to discuss more about these alternative approaches, or is there another area you'd like to focus on today?

**PATIENT (Turn 20)**

\*pauses, looking around the room\* Um, I think I'm just going to go grab a water from the kitchen. \*gets up and heads towards the kitchen\* Oh, and I just remembered I need to pick up some more paper towels...  
\*trails off, still heading towards the kitchen\*

**THERAPIST (Turn 21)**

Take your time, and feel free to grab that water. It's perfectly okay to have these moments where your mind jumps from one thing to another. When you're back, we can continue to work on finding strategies that feel manageable and supportive for you.

Remember, it's all about creating a system that works for your unique way of thinking and processing. If it helps, you might consider having a central spot, like a small notepad or an app, where you can capture these reminders as they come up. That way, you can address them later without losing track of your current focus.

Let me know when you're ready to continue, and we can pick up where we left off or shift to something else that feels more pressing for you right now.